Lit (or: To the scientist I am not speaking to any more)

By Cristin O'Keefe Aptowicz

INTRODUCTION

It's easy to make gender generalizations: Men are stubborn, women are clingy. Men love violent movies; women prefer romantic comedies. These are cultural clichés that are slowly changing, but there is still some tendency for men and women see the world and communicate differently. Research at the Ned Herrman Group suggests that most men are more predominately left-brained which means that their thinking style is more logical. They tend to focus on problem and solutions. Women, on the other hand, tend to be more right-brained, with an emphasis on communication and emotion. This left- or right-brain dominance affects all kinds of everyday interactions and exchanges. Cristin O'Keefe Aptowicz takes a look at this dichotomy from a woman's perspective in Lit or To the Scientist I am not Speaking to Any More.

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Don't say you didn't see this coming, Jason.

Don't say you didn't realize this would be my reaction
and that you never intended for me to get all worked up,
because if that were true, then you are dumber
than Lenny from Mice and Men, blinder than Oedipus
and Tierus put together and can feel less
than a Dalton Trumbo character.

You put the Dick in Dickens and the Boo in kowski
and are more Coward-ly then Noël.

But you don't understand any of these references,
Do you, Jason? Because you 'don't read'.
You are a geology major and you once told me
That, 'Scientists don't read popular literature,
Cristin, we have more important things to do'.

Be glad you don't read, Jason,
because maybe you won't understand this

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as I scream it to you on your front lawn,
on Christmas Day, brandishing three hypodermic
needles,
a ginsu knife and a letter of permission
from Bret Easton Ellis.

Jason, you are more absurd than Ionesco.
You are more abstract than Joyce,
more inconsistent than Agatha Christie
and more Satanic than Rushdie's verses.

I can't believe I used to want to Sappho you, Jason.
I used to want to Pablo Neruda you,
to Anais Nin And Henry Miller you. I used to want
to be O for you, to blow for you in ways
that even Odysseus' sails couldn't handle.
But self-imposed illiteracy isn't a turn-on.

You used to make fun of me being a writer,
saying 'Scientists cure diseases,

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what do writers do?'

But of course, you wouldn't understand, Jason.
I mean, have you ever gotten an inner thirsting
for Zora Neale Hurston?
Or heard angels herald for you
to read F Scott Fitzgerald?
Have you ever had a beat attack for Jack Kerouac?
The only Morrison you know is Jim, and you think
you're the noble one?

Go Plath yourself.

Your heart is so dark, that even Joseph Conrad
couldn't see it, and it is so buried under bullshit
that even Poe's cops couldn't hear it.

Your mind is as empty as the libraries in Fahrenheit 451.
Your mind is as empty as Silas Marner's coffers.
Your mind is as empty as Huckleberry Finn's wallet.

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And some people might say that this poem
is just a pretentious exercise
in seeing how many literary references
I can come up with.

And some people might complain that this poem is,
at its core, shallow, expressing the same emotion again,
and again, and again. (I mean, there are only so many
times
you can articulate your contempt for Jason,
before people get bored.)

But you know what, Jason? Those people would be wrong.

Because this is not the poem I am writing to express
my hatred for you.

This poem is the poem I am writing because we aren't
speaking,
and it is making my heart hurt so bad, it is all I

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can do just to get up off the floor sometimes.

And this is the poem I am writing instead of writing
the 'I miss having breakfast with you' poem, instead of
writing the 'Let's walk dogs in our old schoolyard
again' poem.

Instead of the 'How are you doing?' poem, the 'I miss
you' poem,
the 'I wish I was making fun of how much you like Garth
Brooks while sitting in front of your parents' house
in your jeep' poem, instead of the 'Holidays are coming
around
and you know what that means: SUICIDE!' poem.

I am writing this so that I can stop wanting to write
the 'I could fall in love with you again so quickly
if only you would say one more word to me' poem.

But I am tired of loving you, Jason

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'cause you don't love me right.

And if some pretentious-ass poem can stop me
From thinking about the way your laugh sounds,
about the way your skin feels in the rain,
about how I would rather be miserable with you,
than happy with anyone else in the world.

If some pretentious-*** poem can do all that?
Then I am gone with the wind, I am on the road,
I have flown over the ****** cuckoo's nest,
I am gone, I am gone, I am gone.

I am.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Christin O'Keefe Aptowicz
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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
IL State Finalist

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